

information included on every credit report: your credit information; public record information; inquiries by others to view your credit history; and your personal information.

#1 Personal Information

The obvious: your name, social security number, date of birth, current and previous addresses, telephone numbers, and current and previous employers. When the government starts handing out serial numbers to consumers, I'm sure that will be on there too. Your checking and savings account balances are NOT included on your credit report, nor is info involving your personal affiliations and background, from religious leanings to doctors' records to past legal problems.

#2 Credit Information

It is all here – the good, the bad, and the ugly...and the boring. The details of all your loans and credit cards are listed with the specific information for each one: the date you opened the account; your credit limit; your balance; your monthly payments, etc. It shows the positive credit information, and of course, it shows the negative information.

#3 Public Record Information

This section is exactly what the name suggests. If there is something on you on public record, it's here. This can run the gamut from legal judgments to tax liens, and don't think the information simply goes away, as it often lingers for years. You may want your past to stay in the past, but your credit report can sometimes be a glaring reminder.

#4 Inquiries

The credit report lists everybody who is checking you out. You need to check it out. Make sure that people are not inquiring into your personal affairs that have no right to be doing so. As I stated earlier, only those with a legitimate purpose – like those who are thinking about giving you money or a credit card – are allowed to see your credit report. Whoever is taking a peek stays listed on your credit report for two years.